Seldon Manifolds — Psychological Grounding

Forward Models, Acceptable Regions, and the Aperture of One Embodiment

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DRAFT — draft-2026-08-29.3 r2 (29 August 2026). Circulated for comment, not as a finished result. This is the grounding companion to *Seldon Manifolds — Theory*, which sets out what a Seldon manifold is and how it works; this paper asks only whether one particular substrate implements anything of that shape. Sections marked as falsifiability commitments are the intended points of attack.

Abstract

The Seldon manifold is a construct built to do forecasting, not a model of human cognition, so nothing here bears on whether it works. What this companion asks is narrower and worth asking on its own account: does a biological nervous system implement anything of that shape, and if so with what horizon, what resolution, and over which dimensions. The answer is that several components are implemented and well measured — a forward model, an acceptable *region* rather than a target with correction only on deviations that would leave it, resolution degrading with temporal distance in a known functional form, and boundaries indexed to the body rather than to the world — while the composite is not. The measured motor horizon is on the order of a hundred and fifty milliseconds and exists to cancel sensory delay; deliberative search runs about three steps deep and is truncated by a reflex rather than by a cost calculation; and within-frame forecasting is good where a domain has recurrent structure to hold and worth nothing where it does not. The honest summary is that the pieces are real, the human instantiation is narrow, and its quality is frame-relative rather than general. One line of evidence the construct would most naturally have leaned on — that representations coarsen with psychological distance — does not survive its best-powered test, and is not relied upon here.

1 Scope

This paper is a grounding and not a validation, and the distinction is load-bearing. The construct it grounds was built as engineering, to forecast; it makes no claim about how people think, so evidence that people forecast badly would not count against it. What such evidence does is characterise one implementation. Where the psychology is unflattering it is therefore reported as a measurement of that implementation's limits rather than as an objection, and where it is flattering it is reported without the suggestion that the construct needed it.

Two consequences follow for how this paper should be read. Findings are organised by the component they bear on — horizon, resolution, represented dimensions, fields, the acceptable region, and the capacity to reshape rather than navigate — rather than by the literature they come from, so several mature research traditions appear here in pieces. And a component may be well evidenced while the composite is not; nothing below argues that any nervous system holds a Seldon manifold, only that each part of one has an implemented counterpart somewhere, mostly in different systems and at wildly different timescales.

2 Forward models, and a horizon of milliseconds

The least controversial forward model in biology is the motor one. A forward model in this sense takes the current state and the outgoing motor command and predicts the next state [38], and the evidence that the nervous system runs one is behavioural rather than inferential: sensory consequences of self-produced movement are attenuated in proportion to how well they are predicted, so that perturbing the timing or trajectory of a self-administered tactile stimulus restores the sensation it would otherwise have suppressed [2], with a delay of roughly a hundred milliseconds sufficient to break the attenuation [28]. Prediction is also learned before control is [12], which separates the forward model from the controller that uses it.

The horizon of that model has been measured, and it is short. Disrupting the lateral cerebellum by stimulation makes reaches behave as though planned from a hand position around 138 ms out of date, replicated at 134 ms, with the authors' upper estimate 150–160 ms [37]. That figure is not an incidental limitation but the model's reason for existing: the feedback loops it compensates run at twenty to sixty milliseconds spinally and around a hundred visually, and a predictor that cancels them needs exactly that much lead. The motor forward model is a delay compensator rather than a simulator of futures, and the gap between it and a deliberative horizon is not bridged by any evidence in this paper.

Remark 2.1 (What this does and does not license). It licenses the claim that a nervous system maintains a predictive model of its own next states and acts on the prediction rather than on the measurement. It does not license any claim about the length of a planning horizon, and a reader who takes the two together is making an architectural argument that the evidence here does not supply.

3 An acceptable region, and correction only on departure

The theory paper holds that a frame may represent a region of acceptable futures and intervene only when its projection leaves that region. Motor control implements something with this shape, and the implementation is measured twice over.

The first is structural. Partitioning the variability of a practised movement into components that do and do not affect the task outcome shows that variance within the task-equivalent subspace is left alone while variance that would change the outcome is corrected — the *uncontrolled manifold* [51]. The nervous system is not stabilising a trajectory; it is stabilising a region and permitting drift inside it.

The second is theoretical and derived rather than assumed. Under optimal feedback control the resulting policy exhibits what its authors name the *minimal intervention* principle: deviations from the average trajectory are corrected only when they interfere with task performance [59].

Remark 3.1 (Three cautions on the correspondence). The principle is *minimal* intervention, not minimum: its criterion is task relevance, not magnitude, and the same analysis permits deviations to be *magnified* where doing so reduces cost. It is therefore not a smallest-sufficient-push result and should not be cited as one. And the controller does not project forward at decision time: the horizon is consumed offline in a backward pass, leaving an online policy that is a single operation on a state estimate. An architecture that re-projects at each step is closer to receding-horizon control, which Todorov and Jordan [59] treat as a separate approach.

The idea that acting well means keeping a projection inside a region is older than either result. Driving was described in 1938 in terms of a *field of safe travel*, an explicitly spatial region of acceptable trajectories within which the driver steers [15], a formulation whose computational descendants still maintain a perceived risk field below a threshold [29].

4 The acceptable region is Simon's claim, not a simplification of it

Satisficing is usually reported as accepting the first option above a threshold, which is a scalar cutoff on one dimension. That is not what the original says. The aspiration level adapts — the balance between what is needed and what is available is maintained by *raising and lowering* aspiration levels — and the criterion is conjunctive across needs, a path being sought that permits satisfaction at some specified level of *all* of them [53]. Simultaneous minima on every need dimension describe a region in a multi-dimensional space, and the fixed scalar version is explicitly the disposable simplification of a toy organism.

The formal development followed: aspiration adaptation theory treats goals as a *vector* with an aspiration on each component, adjusted against feasibility [52], and non-compensatory conjunctive models — a cutoff per attribute with no trade-offs between them — have been fitted to choice process data in preference to compensatory alternatives [10, 58]. That the aspirations adapt to the environment rather than sitting fixed is itself measured [6].

Remark 4.1 (Where the region is genuinely absent). Several familiar constructs look like acceptable regions and are not. A reference point is one point on one axis with a kink, below which outcomes are treated continuously differently rather than categorically [26]; safety-first criteria minimise the probability of falling below a level, which is a half-line [46]; and aspiration in the risk-preference literature, while a genuine second criterion rather than a reshaped utility function, remains a scalar cutoff [32]. The distinction between a threshold on a scalar and a region in several dimensions is exactly where an account can go wrong: the best-known attempt to explain accident rates by a single target level of risk failed, and failed because it collapsed a field to one scalar on one variable [11, 63].

5 Resolution falls with horizon

The theory paper treats resolution and horizon as separate axes under a shared budget, with resolution characteristically degrading as horizon extends. There is a measured version of this with a functional form. In interval timing the standard deviation of an estimate is proportional to the interval being estimated, so the coefficient of variation stays constant as the interval grows [14, 45, 65]. Absolute uncertainty therefore scales with distance: the further out, the coarser, in a fixed ratio. The result is fifty years old, holds across species, and is not in dispute.

Remark 5.1 (A stronger candidate that does not survive). There is an obvious alternative anchor, and it should be named because a reader will otherwise supply it. Construal level theory holds that the further an object is from direct experience the more abstract its representation [60], which is resolution falling with distance stated for cognition generally rather than for timing. A meta-analysis of over two hundred experiments reported a reliable medium effect [56]. But a registered multi-laboratory replication across four distance types, with nearly twelve thousand participants, found effects of $d \approx 0.03$–0.08 with the social effect reversed, and a bias-corrected re-analysis of the existing literature finds strong evidence of publication bias [4, 33]. The theory's authors contest the replication [31], and both critical papers are preprints, so the accurate statement is that the effect is in serious dispute rather than that it is refuted — and either way it cannot carry weight. The timing result above is narrower and secure, and is used instead.

6 Horizon is plural and frame-relative

A single agent does not have one horizon. Cortical regions differ systematically in the window over which they integrate information, from tens of milliseconds in sensory areas to many seconds in higher-order ones [22, 23], and predictive representations differ in reach along the same

gradient, with anterior prefrontal cortex showing the largest predictive horizons and posterior hippocampus the smallest [3]. Different subsystems hold different horizons over the same world, which is the theory paper's frame-relativity appearing within one skull rather than between agents.

7 The manifold is indexed to the body

The strongest support in this paper is for the claim that different agents hold different manifolds of one situation, with no frame-free manifold that theirs approximate. The boundary between a stairway that can be climbed and one that cannot is not a property of the stairway: it scales to the observer's leg length and matches biomechanical prediction [61], and the boundary between an aperture that can be walked through and one requiring rotation sits at a constant ratio of aperture to shoulder width, recovered from body-scaled optical information [62]. The same physical situation has measurably different boundaries for different bodies, and there is no body-free version of the boundary for either of them to be wrong about.

Remark 7.1 (The extension is not free)*.* This is the perception of immediately available action, not a multi-step future. That the same frame-relativity holds of extended horizons is an argument the theory paper makes and this literature does not supply.

8 Bounded search, and how it stops

Measured planning depth is shallow. Where it has been fitted directly it runs to roughly three steps, and subjects trade depth against precision under a near-constant workload, preferring to reduce depth rather than compute less precisely [55]; deep problems are approached by concatenating shallow searches rather than by deepening them, with subgoal selection chosen so as to nearly minimise the cost of computing values [25].

How the search stops is less comfortable for any account that wants a cost-benefit rule. Branches are pruned reflexively on encountering a large loss, and the pruning persists when it is made overwhelmingly counterproductive [24]. The same subjects show near-optimal subgoal selection and a hard-wired affective guillotine in the same task [25]. The honest reading is that stopping is heuristic in mechanism and only approximately rational in aggregate.

Remark 8.1 (Shallow search is not a shallow forward model)*.* It would be a mistake to infer from three-step search that the forward representation is impoverished, and there is a better-supported alternative. People appear to hold a precomputed, horizon-discounted predictive map of expected future occupancy — flexible when rewards change, insensitive when the sequence of states changes — rather than either searching a tree or caching a policy [41]. Such a map is much closer to a manifold with fields over it than tree search is, and it explains shallow measured search without impoverishing the representation. The caveat is that it is a compressed occupancy prediction rather than a branching structure with explicit alternatives, so it under-delivers on reachable futures in the plural.

9 Within-frame quality, and why it does not transfer

Forecasting quality inside a frame can be very high, and it is not bought by searching further. Replicating the classical result across skill levels finds that stronger players search *faster*, not deeper, with pattern recognition rather than search the principal discriminator [7, 8]; the sharpest demonstration is that a grandmaster's rated strength falls only slightly when playing six boards simultaneously against tournament-length thinking time [17]. Depth differences with skill are not zero [5], so recognition should be called the principal discriminator rather than the only one.

The anticipation is genuinely prospective where it has been isolated: skilled performers respond to advance kinematic information before the event they are anticipating occurs, with the effect established across dozens of studies and hundreds of effect sizes [34, 42], and the advantage disappears when attention is forced elsewhere [43].

It also does not transfer. Far transfer from trained domains shrinks as study design improves and vanishes against active controls [35, 48, 49]. The mechanism predicts this rather than merely tolerating it: a store of domain-structured patterns has nothing to decode a foreign domain against. The complementary case is forecasting in a domain without stable recurrent structure, where experts do no better than simple statistical models or informed crowds [13] — though within the same literature domain expertise still predicts accuracy, and calibration improves with training and aggregation [36]. Where structure exists the map forms; where it does not, expertise buys nothing.

Remark 9.1 (One control is weaker than usually reported)*.* The random-position control is often cited as showing that expert advantage vanishes without domain structure. It does not fully vanish: strong players retain a smaller but real advantage on random material, and it generalises across fields [18, 50]. The non-transfer claim above rests on the far-transfer meta-analyses, not on this control.

10 Blind spots, reshaping, and the growth of the dimension set

Three further components have implemented counterparts.

Blind spots are real and are not introspectively accessible. People report understanding complex phenomena with far greater precision and depth than they possess, and discover this only on attempting explanation [47]; attended observers miss salient unexpected events entirely [54]; and adults who can distinguish their own knowledge from another's routinely fail to deploy that distinction online [27]. This supports the theory paper's treatment of a blind spot as a distinct deficit from coarseness, and rules out any mechanism in which a frame audits its own dimension set from inside.

Reshaping rather than navigating is implemented. Committing in advance so as to remove a future option is a documented and modelled behaviour [1, 44], and the broader category of changing one's situation rather than choosing within it is treated as a distinct class of self-control [9].

The dimension set can grow. Perceptual learning includes attentional weighting, differentiation and unitisation, and people demonstrably learn to separate dimensions that were previously fused [19, 20]. A represented dimension set is therefore not fixed, which the theory paper requires and does not otherwise evidence.

11 What the evidence does not support

Four things should be stated plainly, since a grounding paper that reports only the matches is not worth reading.

The composite is not evidenced. Every component above is implemented somewhere, but in different systems, at timescales separated by three orders of magnitude, and no study assembles them. That a nervous system holds a Seldon manifold is not shown here and is not claimed.

Whether the machinery is required is unresolved. Patients with hippocampal amnesia have been reported both as unable to construct coherent imagined experiences [21] and as unimpaired at imagining the future [57], with a third position arguing that the verbal measures used cannot adjudicate between them [39]. The dispute is live. It is compatible with the theory paper's treatment of the manifold as optional machinery, but it should be presented as unresolved rather than as settled favourably.

Forecasting error is on magnitude, not structure — and this is a reframing. People systematically overestimate the intensity and duration of their future emotional reactions [16, 64]. Much of the effect appears to be an artefact of how the question is interpreted [30], and when measured in daily life people predict correctly *which* events will make them feel better or worse while erring on absolute levels [40]. A manifold whose shape is right and whose field magnitudes are miscalibrated is what this describes. That is a legitimate reading and it is still a reading, offered as such.

The per-agent axes are not established. The theory paper allows different frames to differ independently in horizon, resolution and represented dimensions. No study assembled here measures those in one sample, and at least one natural axis does not separate — imagery vividness and richness of future simulation covary rather than dissociating. Separable per-agent axes are a synthesis, not a finding.

12 Falsifiability commitments

- **A predictive forward model.** Fails if the attenuation of self-produced sensation does not track prediction error, or if prediction is not separable from control.
- **Region rather than target.** Fails if task-irrelevant variability is corrected as strongly as task-relevant variability, i.e. if there is no uncontrolled subspace.
- **Resolution scaling with distance.** Fails if the coefficient of variation of temporal estimates is not approximately constant across intervals.
- **Body-indexed boundaries.** Fails if perceived action boundaries do not scale with the relevant bodily dimension, or if one boundary fits all bodies.
- **Structure-dependent forecasting.** Fails if within-domain forecasting advantage is independent of the domain's recurrent structure, or if it transfers to unrelated domains under active controls.
- **Scope.** This paper is falsified as over-claiming if any section is read as evidence that a nervous system holds a Seldon manifold, or as validation of a construct that does not require it.

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